

“business.” At the very least, a lot of the advice you hear is highly conflicted.

To avoid bad advice, you must always ask yourself: “What is this person selling?” Once you figure out what the product is, you can put the sales “advice” into better context.

Allow me to disclose what I’m selling—my product—so you can get a sense of how much weight you may wish to put on my words:

- *Content*: Whether it’s this book, my podcasts, or columns, I want you to consume my ideas and embrace my philosophy. Some of this is altruism—I love getting emails from people telling me how much investment angst they avoided due to something I wrote. But do not be naïve: Everyone who does this is engaging in branding and marketing (me included).
- *Time*: Even free blog posts and podcasts have a cost—you pay for that content with your time and attention. I love asking an audience what product radio or TV sells; the answer is invariably “advertising.” That answer is incorrect. When something is free, we overlook that *we are the product*. Our attention is being sold to advertisers, along with our data. And that gets cross-referenced to include your web browsing habits, geographic location, credit score, income, purchase history, and a whole lot more.
- *Investment management*: My firm runs ~\$5 billion for a few thousand families. We charge a fee for our investment and planning services. If we win your business, our firm’s revenues and profits go up. (Sorry to be blunt, but it is a fact.)⁷³

Free advice (especially about money) comes with that caveat. Anytime money gets discussed, you should assume a sales pitch is embedded within. That is especially true when it comes to stocks. The problem, as we have seen, is most of that advice is not very good.